

Breasts

On average, females will start to grow breasts between the ages of 9 and 13 years old, and they usually take 5–6 years to develop fully. Some can't wait for their breasts to develop, but others might feel nervous or uncomfortable as their body changes.

How they work

Breasts are made up of glands and fatty tissue, and lie over the pectoral muscles at the top of the torso. They continue up into the armpits. During puberty, female breasts grow bigger and rounder in response to increased levels of estrogen. As males have low levels of estrogen, their breasts do not typically develop.

A primary function of female breasts is to produce milk to feed and nourish a baby, in a process called lactation, which is controlled by the hormone oxytocin. When the baby sucks on its mother's nipple, a network of ducts transport the milk through the breast and out through tiny holes in the nipple.

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◀ 32–33 Changing body

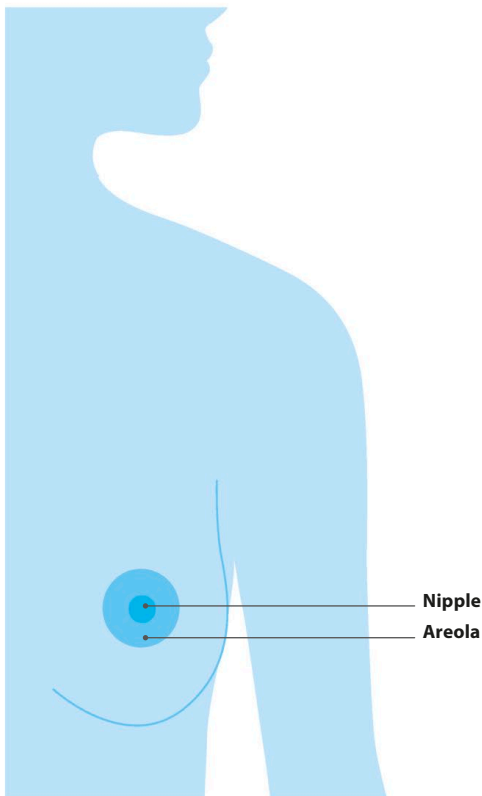
Bras

42–43 ▶

TEEN HINTS

Love your breasts

There is no standard breast or nipple shape. They come in all different shapes, sizes, and colors and all are perfectly natural. Try to love yours, no matter what they look like!



► Inside the breast

Made of glands and fatty tissue, breasts are part of the female reproductive system.

Lobes
Lobes are made up of several lobules where milk is produced after a woman has given birth.

Ducts

